And, it is platform-independent.

Intel's goal in creating the Framework for EFI was to help BIOS vendors support the speed, power and innovations of today's system architectures. This solution offers full legacy support through the use of a compatibility support module, or CSM. For systems that do not as yet have EFI, the support module takes the place of EFI so that the Framework can communicate with the traditional OS.

The Framework has obvious benefits over traditional BIOS. It:

- Improves the reliability of the boot architecture
- Shortens boot times
- Offers full legacy support
- Eliminates VGA dependency
- Can be used with any Intel architecture

Because the Framework has a modular, driver-based architecture, developers can create each BIOS more quickly, and with fewer errors. Each new BIOS can be built with modules that are already tested and verified.

A side benefit to being modular is that the Framework reduces BIOS size and improves boot reliability. This is accomplished through firmware. With the Framework, settings are no longer stored in the CMOS map. Instead, new settings are stored on the firmware chip. Extra or additional drivers and code functions can be stored on the hard drive, and accessed there. This makes it easier for OEMs (Original Equipment Manufacturers) to add systems features that can differentiate them from other products.

Some of the interesting benefits of the Framework are that it:

- Breaks through fundamental BIOS barriers. For example, pre-boot RAM can now be greater than 1 MB, which means developers can control how RAM is allocated, and the Option ROM space crunch is resolved
- Allows a developer to compile pre-tested modules into a working BIOS that is more likely to be efficient and error-free

InsydeH_2O

Insyde Software, a leading global provider of BIOS firmware and software services, announced its next generation PC firmware technology. Insyde also announced a product line aimed at replacing the traditional BIOS. Using 21st century software engineering techniques and tools, Insyde's software, which is based on the driver model, eases the difficulties encountered by PC designers in adapting and advancing their platform-level firmware. And further, because the software is written in C, PC makers will have a wider pool of software engineers to draw upon (BIOS software has always been written in assembly language).

Based on the EFI, this new product line from Insyde debuts under the brand name, InsydeH_2O, representing the next generation 'Hardware-2-Operating System' firmware interface. InsydeH_2O is aimed across a range of market segments, including Desktop, Mobile, Server and Embedded computing. Amongst the benefits that InsydeH_2O provides to ODMs (Original Design Manufacturers) and OEMs are:

- Compatible firmware and development environment across an OEM's entire product line
- A streamlined method for testing and qualifying PCs in manufacturing line
- Greater productivity and lower costs to developing and maintaining firmware technology